

THE DIGITAL CAMERA FOR YOU

You can stop thinking of digital cameras as a luxury item. You can easily use a digital camera instead of the conventional camera and come up with some good prints

Buying it Right

Looking out for the best digital camera for your needs? Check out a few pointers before you settle on one

Check out the ergonomics

While choosing a digital camera, don't just go by the features. Also, look for the ergonomics of the camera. That means, while taking the snap see that the button



The Canon digital camera

placement is within the reach of your fingers and your fingers don't come in the way of the lens or flash. If you are wearing spectacles, then check out for digital cameras that provide you with a focusable diopter in the optical viewfinder. This will ensure that the focal length is automatically adjusted for you.

Selecting the right resolution

It's advisable that you select a digital camera keeping in mind the output medium that you will be typically using it for. For instance, if the snaps from your digital camera will mainly be for the Web, then a camera with a 640x480 resolution will do. For smaller-size printouts, you will need one that supports at least 1024x768 and for bigger size photographs you will need 1600x1200 at the minimum.

Resolving the pixels

While purchasing a digital camera, always go by the resolution and not the CCD count since the CCD count (2.1 megapixels or 3.3 megapixels) is more likely a marketing gimmick and reflects a higher pixel count than the resolution. For instance, a camera with a resolution of 1600x1200 will have a total pixel count of 192,000, whereas if it is slated to have 2.1 megapixels, then the total should be 210,000 pixels.

Zooming into optics

One of the most important features of the digital camera is its lens. Most digital cameras come with a zoom lens with specifications such as optical zoom and digital zoom, of which optical zoom is more important.

Optical zoom means the actual change in the focal length. The optical zoom works by using a system of lenses to refract light and magnify an image on to the CCD.

This means that the quality of image you get is magnified along with the resulting detail and clarity, unlike a digital zoom that magnifies or crops the image and is more of a software function, but the quality of the image suffers and can appear fuzzy. The digital zoom is similar to the interpolation in a scanner.

You could use this optical zoom feature if you intend to take photographs at high resolution and are going to view it on the screen or print it on a photo printer (regular colour printers are not optimised for image printouts and give pixelated images).

In digital cameras, the zoom can be either kept on auto, where the camera decides the focal length depending on the metering you have selected, or on manual mode using which you can

change the focal length manually. Here metering, which refers to the different ways in which the camera detects light conditioning, is very important because if you keep the metering as matrix, the lens will zoom into the most prominent part in the image.

But if the same image is shot using spot metering then the lens will zoom in or out according to the spot and the image will look completely different.

Normally, the cameras will have two numbers marked on them that will tell you the optical zoom and digital zoom available. Normally, a camera will have 3x optical zoom and 4x digital zoom.

Costing for the extras

When you are purchasing a digital camera, don't just look at the cost of the camera but also account for hidden or running costs such as costs of batteries (rechargeable batteries are in that sense preferable), cost for adding more memory at a later stage and other smaller variables like power adapters and the case for the camera.



Casio with its digital camera range

Getting the interface right

We all know that USB will be faster than a serial interface. But you should check out for a USB digital camera not just because of speed.

Apart from the hot plug-in capability, USB also simplifies the ease of use of transfers since the computer thinks of the USB device as another drive. So, you

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